Breath Sounds

by Jane Nicolaas



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SCENE ONE

PAIGE. (*PAIGE directly addresses the audience.*) They tell you in med school that your first year as a doctor is the hardest. You learn the most. You lose the most. If you're lucky, you find what you love. By the time I arrived at my internal medicine rotation, I was sure I had it all figured out. Life and death. Luck and love. These were all very separate parts. Then I met Evan.

PAIGE. (*PAIGE is now "in-scene" and addresses EVAN off-handedly.*) Okay, I'm sorry for the wait.

EVAN. It's no problem. I've got all the time in the world.

PAIGE. (*looks at him with surprise and mild annoyance before rifling through papers*) Right. (*She finds his chart and reads the list of answers aloud without realizing what she's saying.*) You are Evan Carter, a 24-year-old male, son of Fred and Wilma Flintstone, presents with advanced (*beat*) menstrual cramps.

EVAN. Do go on.

PAIGE. Okay. (*turns to leave*) Have a nice day, Mr. Carter.

EVAN. You're leaving?

PAIGE. I have a lot of patients to see--patients with medical histories that aren't a big joke.

EVAN. It's not all a big joke.

PAIGE. Some of the answers are drawings.

EVAN. Well, my name is Evan Carter, and I'm dying of cystic fibrosis. I guess the details are sort of a joke.

PAIGE. (*addressing the audience*) Now, I know that doctors are typically meant to heal. We close wounds. We don't open them. But I don't think there was anything typical about this whole thing.

SCENE TWO

PAIGE. (*addressing the audience*) As a Doctor, you never want to see your patients return time and again, but every time he came back to the hospital I felt something in me. It felt suspiciously like joy.

PAIGE. (*returns to scene*) Hello again, Mr. Carter.

EVAN. What's up, doc?

PAIGE. (*looks over his chart*) Back so soon? I don't think I like that.

EVAN. Not even a little?

PAIGE. Maybe we should switch your medication regimen.

EVAN. Nah, I'm ok. I just like it here. You guys have got cable.

PAIGE. (*running tests on him*) Well, you've got good timing. Breathe in. Detroit is playing Chicago tonight. Breathe out.

EVAN. You like football?

PAIGE. I love football, now shush and breathe in.

EVAN. Do you like pizza?

PAIGE. Breathe out. I do. I also like breath sounds so stop talking.

EVAN. I'll make you a deal. I will shut up and pay for pizza if you come watch the game with me tonight.

PAIGE. I can't.

EVAN. Well in that case…(*proceeds to sing loudly*) la la la…you get no breath sounds…la la la.

PAIGE. Evan. Evan! Ugh, fine! I'll stop by if I can. You're so annoying.

SCENE THREE

PAIGE*.* (*addresses audience*) He was like that song on the radio. You don't want to like it, but it's happy, catchy, and always there. And before I knew what I was doing, I was humming along.

EVAN. (*both hunched over a chess board*) You can't do that.

PAIGE. Yes I can.

EVAN. No, the horsey moves…

PAIGE. (*laughs*) The horsey?

EVAN. Yes, he moves in an L shape. You can't. (*They start to tussle over the chess piece. They are laughing hysterically until EVAN launches into an intense coughing fit that leads to him hyperventilating. She is quick to react. PAIGE moves behind him and quickly grabs the breathing mask. She puts it on him. He continues to breathe erratically as she cradles him against her.*)

PAIGE. Shhh. Evan. Shh. Listen to me. Breathe when I breathe. (*They breathe together. He slowly calms down until they are left silently breathing. They share a moment that is intimate, heated, and doomed. PAIGE stands to leave but EVAN holds on to her hand. She stares at it for a moment and then slips away.*)

SCENE FOUR

PAIGE. (*addresses audience*) I fought to stay away from him. I really did, but what can I say? It was Evan. He was nothing if not a fighter.

EVAN. Hey, doc, wait! (*chases her out, wheezing*) Don't you know it's cruel to make a guy with cystic fibrosis run?

PAIGE. Mr. Carter. I'm a doctor. I'm busy. What do you need?

EVAN. I guess I need some forceps to remove the I.V. stand from up your butt.

PAIGE. Have a good day, Mr. Carter.

EVAN. Whoa, make that the jaws of life! What is your problem?

PAIGE. You're making a scene. (*drags him into a storage closet*)

EVAN. You dragged me into the storage closet. Now who's making a scene?

PAIGE. Stop, Evan. Just stop. This isn't a joke.

EVAN. She said standing by the enema bags.

PAIGE. Don't you get it? I am not allowed to do this.

EVAN. You're not allowed to do what?

PAIGE. (*exasperated*) I'm not allowed to feel like this.

EVAN. You're not allowed to feel? Are you sure this isn't a joke?

PAIGE. (*She relents into laughter.*)

EVAN. You have a beautiful smile.

PAIGE. (*She sighs and lets her guard down.*) What are we doing? You're stage four CF, and you've only got 33% lung function.

EVAN. And I'm highly accident-prone. I can't take anything seriously. Oh, and I cheat at chess.

PAIGE. You cheat at chess?

EVAN. The point is: I don't have a point. Maybe, it's just me breathing when you breathe for as long as I can.

SCENE FIVE

PAIGE. (*addresses audience*) That's the sickest part of all of this. He knew. We both knew from minute one exactly how this would end. But over the next five months we did what people in impossible situations do, we fell hopelessly in love.

EVAN. (*PAIGE returns to the scene. EVAN's breathing is noticeably more labored.)* Did you always want to be a doctor?

PAIGE. Always.

EVAN. (*He laughs but it prompts a painful fit of coughing.)*

PAIGE. Evan?

EVAN. (*He ignores the coughing and pushes through to talk.)* I can totally see you, "I need 50cc's of Kool-Aid and a teddy bear… STAT!" (*He coughs again. He is frustrated and in pain.*)

PAIGE. (*tries to soothe him*) Evan.

EVAN. I'm fine. (*EVAN continues coughing. PAIGE gets his breathing mask but he pushes it away.)* I'm fine!

PAIGE. Okay, you're fine. (*EVAN takes the mask and shoves it on his face. PAIGE sighs and then tries to lighten up.*) What did you want to be when you grew up?

EVAN. Alive.

PAIGE. Don't say that.

EVAN. It was a joke.

PAIGE. Well it's not a funny joke, Evan.

EVAN. Whoa, calm down, doc.

PAIGE. I hate that. You make these awful jokes and then act like there's something wrong with me for not giggling, "Oh, ha-ha, you're dying. Ha-ha!"

EVAN. Well, excuse me for not crying about it all the time.

PAIGE. All the time? Try doing it once.

EVAN. That's not how I deal with it.

PAIGE. Do you deal with it?

EVAN. (*stares at her*) I wanted to be Big Bird.

PAIGE. (*smiles a little*) You could be a great Big Bird.

EVAN. Yeah, but I'm running out of time. (*awkward moment*) Mitt Romney's going to fire him soon.

PAIGE. Yeah.

SCENE SIX

PAIGE. *(addresses audience)* It was getting worse. Sometimes it sounded like a single laugh would be enough to break him in half. But he kept on laughing, which made it all seem better and worse.

PAIGE. (*PAIGE sneaks in. EVAN has his breathing mask on.)* Hey.

EVAN. (*starts to remove the mask*)

PAIGE. No, no. It's ok. Leave it.

EVAN. (*He relaxes. His breathing is heavy and painful.*) What's up, doc?

PAIGE. (*She struggles a bit.*) Ugh, how many times do I have to call you to call me Paige. It's weird that you call me "doc."

EVAN. (*He tries to calm her as she is clearly losing it.*) Hey. What's going on?

PAIGE. Your tests came back, Ev. It's not good news.

EVAN. It was never going to be.

PAIGE. (*starts to cry*)

EVAN. Shh… Paige…

PAIGE. This is stupid. I am stupid. I am sitting here right now, and every moment you get closer to dying I fall more in love with you.

EVAN. Shhh… Paige…shh. Listen to me: breathe when I breathe. (*She slowly calms down.*) I love you, too.

PAIGE. What am I going to do when you leave me?

EVAN. I won't ever leave you, Paige. You'll breathe and you'll feel me breathing with you.

PAIGE. That's romantic.

EVAN. Romantic? I'm talking about haunting you as a ghost.

PAIGE. You're annoying.

SCENE SEVEN

PAIGE. (*addresses audience*) It was a matter of time. It always is.

PAIGE. (*on the phone*) Hello. Is this Paul Carter? Hi, this is Dr. Paige. (*gets interrupted on the other end)*

Oh, Evan's told me a lot about you, too.

Well, I'm…I'm calling with some bad news. (*stops for a moment to compose herself*) The respiratory drugs we had your son on caused a blood clot to form in his lungs. It got into his bloodstream and traveled into his brain. Evan had a stroke this morning and—Yes, sir. I was there with him. I was holding his hand. I—*we*—did everything we could.

PAIGE. (*addresses audience*) And just like that, in the blink of an eye, in the space of one breath, it all came tumbling down.

SCENE EIGHT

PAIGE. (*PAIGE enters the room and EVAN is still in the hospital bed. A respirator has replaced his breathing. It is hard for her to see him like this. She goes and reads his chart out of habit. A letter falls out.*) What is this? "Dear Paige," Oh god. (*sits down*) "Dear –"

EVAN. Paige. I don't know when or how I went, but I promise I fought to stay. I thought about writing out another medical history, maybe something like, "presents with advanced death." But you were right: not everything is a joke. We were never a joke. Maybe I didn't say it enough, maybe you thought I was joking, or maybe you just needed to know once and for all that you are the love of my life. I am grateful for every breath.

SCENE NINE

PAIGE. (*addresses audience*) Your first year as a doctor you definitely learn the most, you lose the most, and—if you're lucky—you find what you love. I don't know if a lot of people would consider me lucky, but I do. I found joy in sadness. I found laughter in tears. I still feel him when I breathe in and when I breathe out. I feel him and that makes me feel very lucky.